



**RICKY PONTING
(RIGHT) FELL VICTIM TO
ISHANT SHARMA FIVE
TIMES IN SEVEN TESTS
WITHIN A YEAR**

England, a slower ball, how to straighten one or when to ping another past the batsmen's ears. It is Sehwa who identifies the younger man's singular strength, probably in part because it is his own. He says, "Ishant doesn't worry about the pitch or the batsman. He only wants to put the ball in the area from where he can get a wicket."

When giants like Ricky Ponting or Matthew Hayden have loomed, Sehwa has often walked across to offer Sharma a relaxing tip: "Imagine you're bowling against Himachal Pradesh." Often the supportive senior chips in with a running commentary too, Sharma recounting in an interview how Sehwa once called his bowling: "Here's Ishant Sharma from Patel Nagar who is bowling at 130 kmph. Oye, why are you bowling at 130?"

For the rest he is just a regular twenty-something, who spends time off on Facebook or listening to

Punjabi pop. His famous mane is Samsonesque superstition and all else he tries to take care of is his weekly visits to Hanuman temples on Tuesdays.

He has just bought a new house not far from the narrow alleys of Ranjit Nagar and the home where he grew up with his parents, sister, four uncles and their families. He will miss the old place, but won't have to sleep in the living room anymore and the new street will be able to accommodate the car he's just been awarded.

As Sharma heads into his second full season, India will cross its fingers. Fitness can be a treacherous acquaintance and fame the most deceptive of gifts. England are already here for seven ODIs and two Tests with their own set of tyros. For the first time in his career, there will be a reputation that Sharma must acknowledge, respect and respond to: his own. ■

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